

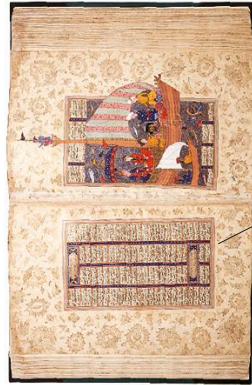


The Middle East

THE MIDDLE EAST IS HOME to the world's oldest civilizations, which grew up in the Tigris and Euphrates river valleys of present-day Iraq more than 6,000 years ago. The world's first towns and cities were built here. Since then, many powerful empires have dominated the region, all leaving a wealth of buildings and monuments behind them. Today, the Middle East is at the center of the Islamic world. The population of every country is Arab and speaks Arabic, except Iran, where half the population are Farsi-speaking Persians.

OIL PRODUCTION

The Middle East is the world's major oil producer—Saudi Arabia alone produces more than 12 percent of the world's supply. Oil has brought great wealth to the region, in particular to Saudi Arabia and the Gulf States.



The Persian language is written in Arabic script

DESERT WARS

Most international boundaries in the Middle East were drawn by the former European colonial powers, and have often caused conflict. Iraq and Iran fought a bitter eight-year war along their common border from 1980. Since then, further conflicts between Iraq and international forces, as well as against the so-called "Islamic State" terrorist organization, have caused much suffering here.

THE IRANIANS

About half the total population of Iran are Persians, who live in the center and north of the country. Large numbers of Azeris live in the northwest, while Kurds live in the west and Baluchis in the southeast. The official language of Iran is Farsi, but many other languages are also spoken.



ROLE OF WOMEN

Family life is important throughout the Muslim world. The role of women varies from country to country—traditionally, women stay at home and look after the family, but some now work. In public, many cover their head with a hijab, or whole body with a burqa.

